Op Onkar. Positioned between Jemadar Biswas's platoon and Battalion HQ was a platoon from 7 Mahar under the command of Jemadar Mohan Lal that had two Vickers machine guns and at least 32,000 rounds of ammunition; the mortar platoon along with the one platoon from Charlie Company was deployed to the right of Battalion HQ. Captain Mahabir Mangat, having only two days ago relinquished command of Alpha Company, was in the communications bunker next to Battalion HQ.

Serious and reserved, Captain Gurucharan Singh Bhatia was due to get married after his NEFA tenure. Every evening the unit gramophone would play love songs while the field telephone was held next to it so that Bhatia could hear his favourite: *'Teri pyari pyari surat ko kisi ki nazar na lage, chashme baddoor'*. The peace station posting he had been patiently waiting for so that he could get married had finally come. At daybreak on 20 October Captain Bhatia was scheduled to bid the men goodbye and leave for Poona.

Popular and vivacious, Captain Mangat was the life of the battalion. He had an endless stock of Sardar jokes, quite a few of them aimed at himself. His letter to his erstwhile roommate at the IMA, Ian Cardozo (1/5 GR, who retired as a Major General) was perhaps one of the last letters to make it out of Nam Ka Chu: 'It looks like it is I who will go first into battle. I am not able to tell you where I am but we are just short of the McMahon Line. The Chinese hold the high ground and seem to be in great strength. Should they attack we will defend our territory to our very last breath. It is very cold out here and we do not have snow clothing but we will give the Chinese a hot reception if they dare to attack. Will tell you all about it, *IF* and *WHEN* we meet again, I don't know where you are but I wish we were better prepared.'

Delta Company was a Bengali Company and the men were acutely conscious of the fact that unlike the Rajput and Gujjar Companies, they were not battle tested. Rikh was aware of this and had decided to keep them close to Battalion HQ.

The sharp exchange of words with Gurdial Singh earlier in the evening after Rikh had returned from Brigade HQ had only added to the feeling of impending doom. Rikh knew the hour of reckoning was at hand. For days he had done what he was trained to do—follow orders despite the impossibility of the task. He had, time and again, given his frank opinion to Dalvi, then watched helplessly as first the brigade commander, then the